

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Based on global data (2023) from Our World in Data / IHME

Hundreds of Millions Affected



1 in 3

Women will experience major depression in their lifetime



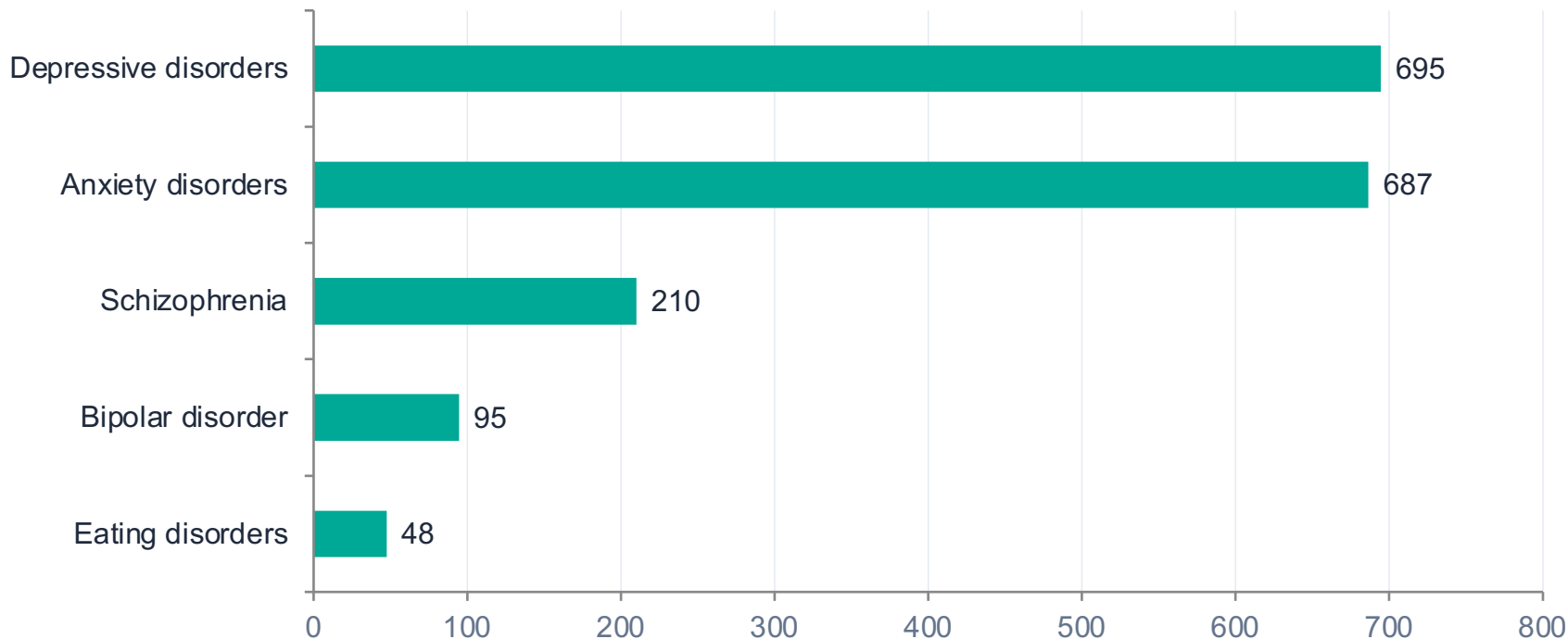
1 in 5

Men will experience major depression in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from highly common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar). A clear understanding of this scale is essential for effective policy planning.

Disease Burden by Category (2023)

Disability-adjusted life years (DALYs) per 100,000 people



Depression and Anxiety Carry Equal Burden

Depressive Disorders

694.6

DALYs per 100,000

Anxiety Disorders

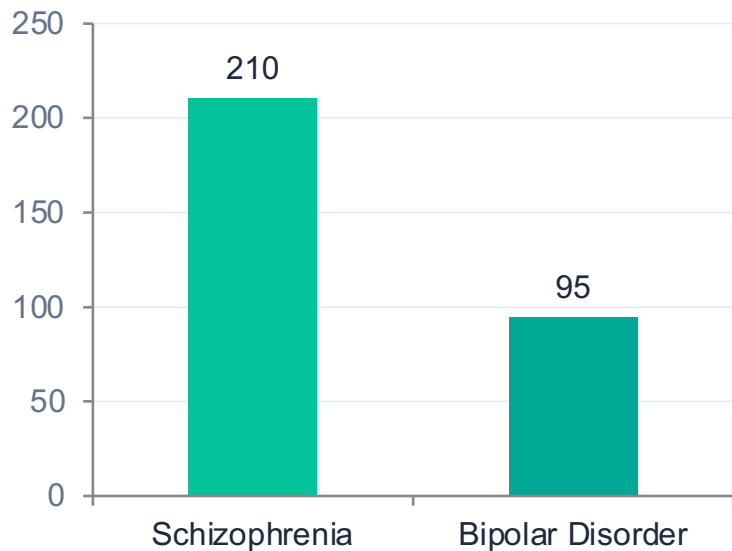
686.5

DALYs per 100,000

Together, they account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across the measured categories, dwarfing other conditions at the population level.

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder

Lower population prevalence, but severe individual impact.



While depressive and anxiety disorders account for the bulk of population-level DALYs, conditions like schizophrenia (210.2 DALYs/100K) contribute a disproportionately high burden per affected individual.

This reflects the severe disability associated with these conditions. Policy must balance broad interventions for common disorders with specialized care for severe conditions.

The Persistent Treatment Gap

Effective treatments exist, but significant barriers prevent access.



Stigma & Discomfort

Many people feel uncomfortable sharing symptoms with professionals or family.



Lack of Access

Treatment is often unavailable, particularly in low- and middle-income regions.



Poor Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be inadequate or poorly administered.



Underreporting

True prevalence is likely underestimated due to fear of disclosure.

Diverse Coping Strategies Globally

Responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors.



Taking Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings with robust health systems.



Engaging in Religious or Spiritual Activities

A widely reported coping mechanism in many regions worldwide.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported foundation of personal support.

Key Takeaways for Policy Planning

- Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs.
- Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden, requiring specialized care.
- Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate, especially globally.
- Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data collection.
- Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.